wamy's Janata Dal (Secular) could do the same with Congress help in 2018. Even if both governments eventually collapsed due to the shifting loyalties of the ruling MLAs (allegedly because of the BJP's poaching politics), their initial success did demonstrate the art of the possible. There is no reason, Nitish is believed to have told the Congress, why this can't be replicated in the general election.

Similarly, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, where the BJP is perceived to be a weak player, together send 101 members to the Lok Sabha. Of these, the BJP could win just four seats in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, and all from Telangana. Nitish's strategy is therefore manifold but also state-specific. He wants the parties to unite in states where the BJP is a strong player, and to closely guard their bases in states where it is weak. "It might sound like an oversimplification, but the fact is that the BJP, at the peak of its popularity, got about 38 per cent votes in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls. That means 62 per cent of the electorate still voted against it. Part of our idea is to consolidate these voters, as much as possible," says a JD(U) leader.

Nitish is also believed to have taken upon himself the job of reaching out to YSR Congress Party chief and Andhra Pradesh CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, as well as Biju Janata Dal boss and Odisha CM Naveen Patnaik. So far, both leaders have not shown any keenness to join the opposition alliance, but, according to a JD(U) leader, Nitish understands that a more consolidated effort in reaching out to them can help the opposition in both pre-poll and post-poll scenarios.

A SECTION IN THE CONGRESS FEELS THAT CEDING SPACE TO REGIONAL PARTIES WILL WEAKEN THE ALREADY WILTING ORGANISATION AND ALSO DEMORALISE WORKERS

THE CONGRESS FACTOR

The Bihar CM has also consistently argued that there can't be a united opposition front without the Congress. He had been pitching for a broad-based opposition unity with the Congress as its pivot since August last year, when he dumped the BJP in Bihar and joined hands with the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), the Congress and four other parties to form a new government. A month after switching alliances, Nitish had also met Rahul and Sonia Gandhi, asking them to work in that direction. Though he was initially unhappy with the Congress for not heeding his proposition, things are finally in motion now, according to sources.

His logic seems sound. The Congress, with or without allies, is among the key players in over 10 states where the BJP has a strong presence. In Gujarat, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, it is in direct contest with the BJP. In Karnataka, Assam and Haryana, it's the leading opposition party, while in West Bengal, Bihar, Maharashtra and Jharkhand, it has significant presence in several pockets. The problem is, the Congress can corner chunks of the anti-BJP votes, damaging the prospects of other stronger opposition players in the process. And that's what it must avoid doing. Nitish has reportedly told the Congress leadership that the party should focus on states where it's strong and play supporting roles in those where others have better chances against the BJP. For instance, in Bihar, it should let the JD(U) and the RJD take a call on seat-sharing, while in Uttar Pradesh, it must cooperate with Akhilesh Yadav. Similarly, in West Bengal, the Congress should not hesitate to play second fiddle to the Trinamool Congress.

The prevailing view in the opposition remains that the Congress needs to cede more ground in terms of the number of seats it contests. Its turf may overlap with that of regional players in some states, but the division of seats must be such that the anti-BJP vote stays intact. "The Congress may consider reviving the now-defunct United Progressive Alliance (UPA). Nitish can be given the responsibility of a convenor—a role George Fernandes played for the NDA earlier—to reach out to other regional chieftains," says the JD(U) source.

The execution of this electoral arrangement will be easier said than done for the Congress leadership. A section in the party believes that ceding space to regional parties and contesting fewer seats will weaken the already wilting organisation. It demoralises party workers, and 'unnatural alliances', such as the one with the Left parties in West Bengal and Tripura, often backfire. More importantly, state leaders zealously guarding their home turfs are usually reluctant for pre-poll sharing with other parties as they fear losing relevance. "It's easier for top leaders to shake hands with opposition leaders for a photo op, but implementing the same on the ground needs the support of state units. It's next to impossible because state leaders know that ground once lost can never be recovered," says a senior Congress MP.

Naturally, the colossal task of uniting the opposition—especially having the Congress accept mutual terms—against a BJP that has become a roaring election machine requires deft poll arithmetic and parleying. And Nitish, with his 17 years as chief minister in addition to six terms in the Lok Sabha, as well as the general warmth he shares with leaders across the board, may just be the right man to navigate these choppy waters. Whether he is also the right man for the country's top post is something he has so far denied. But then that could very well change when such an opportunity does arise. For the moment, Nitish has his task cut out: playing chief negotiator. On it will depend the shape of future politics. ■